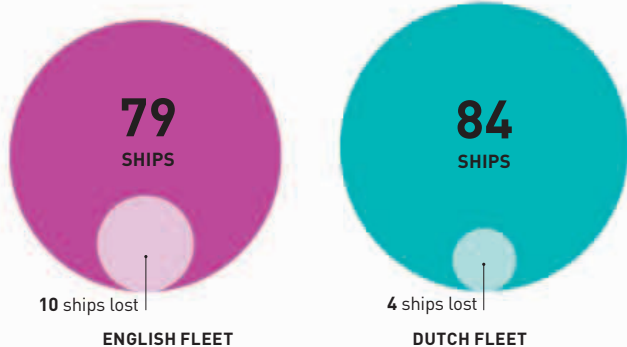




In 1666, a major fire swept through the central parts of London, consuming thousands of houses and wiping away centuries of history.



Four Days' Battle

In one of the longest naval engagements ever, the *Four Days' Battle*, fought in June 1666 during the Second Anglo-Dutch War, saw the Dutch inflict a defeat on the English.

THE BIGGEST ENGAGEMENT OF THE SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR,

which had begun in 1665, the **Four Days' Battle** was an English attempt to destroy the Dutch fleet before it could grow to challenge them. However, the **English** suffered such **losses** that it handed the initiative to the Dutch. Disaster then followed for England in June 1667 after a daring **Dutch raid** on the Medway River, in the Thames estuary. With discontent at home, England brought the war to a halt.

As the Great Plague ended, a new **disaster overtook London**, the **Great Fire**, which burned from September 2 to 5. London was still a medieval city, filthy and unplanned, with no great spaces and few public buildings of note. The City, which was the commercial heart, was especially overcrowded and unsanitary. It was here the fire began. Although the risk of fire was well known, no

effective precautions were taken. Though **drought and a heat wave** had made the city especially vulnerable, a crucial added factor was a strong easterly wind. The result was that the **whole of the City was destroyed**, including the medieval St. Paul's Cathedral, 87 other churches, and upward of 13,000 houses. The official death toll of six has long been disputed.

Not to be outdone by the founding of the Royal Society of London (see 1662), in December 1666 Louis XIV gave his blessing to the creation of the **French Academy of Sciences**, which in 1699 became the Royal Academy of Sciences and was installed in the Louvre Palace, in Paris. Today, it is part of the *Institut de France*. It was at the heart of a **drive for verifiable scientific knowledge**. As an arm of the state it was also interested in discoveries that could enrich its country, such as in agriculture and armaments.

“ **THE MIND IS ITS OWN PLACE AND IN ITSELF, CAN MAKE A HEAVEN OF HELL, A HELL OF HEAVEN.** ”

John Milton, English poet, from *Paradise Lost*, 1667

THE TREATY OF ANDRUSOVO in January 1667 ended the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth's calamitous war with Russia that had begun in 1654. It also climaxed The Deluge—its **dramatic decline** above all in the face of **Russian expansion**. Russia, granted Smolensk and present-day Belarus, could for the first time claim to have **unified the Slavic peoples of the region**.

The completion in 1667 of the **Piazza San Pietro**, by Gian Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680), saw the high point of urban planning in Baroque Rome. Many of Rome's public spaces were ambitiously rebuilt by a series of architects to make them deliberately imposing, and worthy to be at the center of the Catholic Church.

The **War of Devolution** began in May 1667 as a result of Louis XIV's continuing **claims to the Spanish Netherlands**. It saw France take some Habsburg cities in Flanders, as well as Franche-Comté to its east. However, a Triple Alliance of

80,000
THE NUMBER OF
PEOPLE KILLED
IN THE SAMAKHI
EARTHQUAKE
IN AZERBAIJAN

England, Sweden, and the Dutch Republic forced the isolated Louis to return most of his gains by the 1668 **Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle**.

In 1667, the **epic poem** *Paradise Lost*, by English poet John Milton (1608–74), gave the English language one of its **greatest literary achievements**. It told the Christian story of man's fall from grace in the Garden of Eden.

Siege of Lille

Louis XIV directs French forces at Lille during the War of Devolution. Its capture provided one of France's few gains from a frustrating conflict.



A woodcut portrait of the admiral and privateer Henry Morgan.

THE PORTUGUESE TRADING POST AT BOMBAY (Mumbai) had **passed to the English Crown** in 1662 as part of the dowry of Catherine of Braganza, Charles II's Portuguese wife. In 1668, the king leased it to the **East India Company** for an annual rent of £10, making it the Company's third trading post in India after those at Surat and Madras. With Bombay Castle completed in 1675, from 1687 it became the focus of all the Company's trading in India, resisting attempts to storm it by the Mughals and the Dutch.

In 1668, the **Welsh privateer** (state-sponsored raider) **Henry Morgan**, famous for his attacks on Spanish settlements in the Caribbean, succeeded in one of the **most daring assaults ever** when his ships captured the well-protected **Spanish trading city of Porto Bello**, in Panama. It won him both great wealth and further English support for his buccaneering endeavors.

Just as Philip II's seizure of the Portuguese crown in 1580 was a sign of Spanish power, so its **recognition of Portuguese independence in 1668** under the Treaty of Lisbon, which confirmed the House of Braganza as rulers of Portugal, was evidence of its decline. From 1640, Portugal had been in open revolt against Spain, and in June 1665 at the **Battle of Montes Claros** a combined Anglo-Portuguese force inflicted a crushing defeat on them. Close to bankruptcy, and sure of further French hostility, the Spanish had little option but to concede.

January 22 Mughal emperor Shah Jahan dies (b. 1592)

June Four Days' Battle sees Dutch naval victory over English

August 26 Dutch painter Frans Hals dies (b. 1580)

September Great Fire of London

December 22 French Academy of Sciences (Académie des Sciences) founded

December 26 10th Sikh Guru Gobind Singh born (d. 1708)

January 20 Treaty of Andrusovo between Russia and Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth

May 24 War of Devolution begins in Europe

July 31 Treaty of Breda ends Second Anglo-Dutch War

October 18 Emperor Fasilides of Ethiopia dies (b. 1603)

Completion of Piazza San Pietro, Rome

English East India Company gains Bombay

May Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle ends War of Devolution

Treaty of Lisbon: Portugal independent from Spain

July Privateer Henry Morgan captures Porto Bello, Panama